Fireside Chat: John Doerr & Bernie Banks

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Rice University | Door Institute for New Leaders

This interview has been edited for publication.

Welcome & Introductions

PRESIDENT DESROCHES: Good afternoon. It's a pleasure to see so many members of the Rice community gathered for what promises to be a truly thoughtful and inspiring conversation. This afternoon's Fireside Chat sits at the intersection of ideas that define Rice at its best: leadership, innovation, and a commitment to tackling the world's most pressing challenges.

We are especially fortunate to explore these themes with two extraordinary individuals whose work embodies each of them. It is my honor to welcome back to campus John Doerr — a proud Rice Engineering alumnus from the classes of '73 and '74. John has become one of Silicon Valley's most influential venture capitalists. As a partner at Kleiner Perkins, he has helped build companies that have fundamentally reshaped how we live and work, including Google, Amazon, Intuit, and many others.

Many in our community also know John for his visionary support in helping to establish the Doerr Institute for New Leaders here at Rice — an investment that continues to shape generations of students and reflects his belief in the power of leadership to change the world. John has consistently championed bold ideas that address global challenges, particularly in clean energy and climate technology. His recent election to the National Academy of Engineering is a fitting recognition of a career defined by innovation, purpose, and impact.

Many of you also know him as the author of *Measure What Matters*, which has influenced leaders around the world, and *Speed and Scale*, his urgent call to action on the climate crisis. Copies of *Measure What Matters* are available at the front — please grab one on your way out. There are also copies of *Running Down a Dream*, a book John especially recommends for students.

Guiding today's discussion is our very own Bernie Banks, Director of the Doerr Institute for New Leaders. Together, John and Bernie will explore what it means to lead and innovate in a rapidly changing world — questions especially relevant for our students and for all of us committed to shaping the future. Please join me in welcoming John Doerr and Bernie Banks.

JOHN DOERR: Thank you to President DesRoches, Director Banks, Melinda, and all the students, faculty, and staff assembled here today. It's really great to be back at Rice.

What I thought we'd do, in the Rice tradition, is open with a conversation around some big-picture themes, which Bernie will guide us through, and then open it up to whatever topics or questions you'd like to discuss in the second half. We'll use this whiteboard to collect those ideas as we go. I'll turn the program over to you, Bernie.

Part I: Leadership, Life, and Meaning

BERNIE BANKS: Thank you, John. It is wonderful to have you back here at your Rice University. The only thing that could make today better is if you had brought along your beloved wife Ann to join us as well, but I know she's here with us in spirit.

Now, approximately 20 years ago, you shared some insights at a Rice commencement on the topics of life and love. Now a lot has transpired since then. I believe effective leaders most certainly try to positively influence both of those. What have you learned about life and love in the years since you gave that presentation?

JOHN DOERR: The choices you make about life and love cut very deep, and you want to get those right. They're hard to get right — and if they are not right, you want to work on them and adjust them. My belief has been to make meaning in life out of your relationship with others. There are a lot of ways to make meaning out of life, but for me, it was always about the interpersonal and the human. Rice, more than most places, not only allows for that — it encourages it. The college system, being in a cohort with friends and fellow travelers for four years or more, is something special.

Now more than ever, we need mission-oriented leaders who are clear about what matters and why.

BERNIE BANKS: You've brought up mission-oriented leaders. What does it mean to you to be a leader? How do you define it, and who are the people who have shaped your perspective on how you elect to lead every single day?

JOHN DOERR: My favorite definition of a leader comes from Jim Collins, who advises the Doerr Institute. After a year or more of research into leadership, he said: *"Leadership is the art of getting people to want to do what must be done."* Think about that — to want to do, to volunteer, to be enabled to do the tasks that are not obvious but must be done. Effective leaders need very good judgment about that. It requires more than persuasion.

I had a mentor at Intel — badge number three or four — Andy Grove – who was credited with democratizing microchips and computing. He said to me, "Doerr, ideas are easy. It is execution that is everything. And the only way you can do most things of consequence is as part of a

team." Ideas are easy. Execution is everything. It takes a team to win. I believe those ideas are at the heart of the Institute and the practice of leadership.

JOHN DOERR: What's your definition of leadership, Bernie?

BERNIE BANKS: Oh my goodness, John. I'm supposed to be asking the questions! But I'll answer. I think leadership is one thing: it's all about influence. How do you influence people to do something that's mutually beneficial? It has to be mutually beneficial, because if it's only going to benefit you and they're not going to derive any benefit over time, you're not going to be able to lead successfully and repeatedly. You can ask anybody to do anything one time. But to ask them to do it multiple times — that influence process is all about the extension of trust. Ultimately, to me, leaders influence by extending trust that they build every single day by forging powerful relationships that are mutually beneficial.

JOHN DOERR: What are the programs at the Institute that enable that?

BERNIE BANKS: I'm glad you asked! Some of these fine students are engaged in them right now. We have *Activation*, where students work one-on-one with ICF-certified leadership coaches on topics they personally elect to pursue. We have *Catalysts*, which are targeted, competency-based workshops — we'll be running one shortly on how to foster positive momentum. We have *Synthesis*, which uses a group coaching methodology. And we have leadership cohorts and a variety of other programs.

Importantly, all of our programs are opt-in, and all are measured rigorously. We don't just say we've achieved an outcome — we assure we have achieved an outcome. All of it is designed to ensure that every Rice student has the ability to grow in their leadership capacity. In the hope they go out and make a positive difference in the world.

JOHN DOERR: How is their life going to be better?

BERNIE BANKS: Let's ask them. Who here has taken a Doerr Institute program? How do you think your life will be better as a result of the energy you expended on that program?

STUDENT 1: As part of the first-year leadership cohort, I've grown not just as a leader, but as a person. It taught me to be more vulnerable around other people, building a sense of trust within our cohort and allowing me to extend myself into a tight-knit community. That's made me a better leader and a better person.

BERNIE BANKS: Couldn't have said it better myself. Anyone else?

STUDENT 2: I am currently doing Activation, and one thing the program has really inspired me to do is take time in every moment of my day to make those small reflections — to think about what I am doing right now, to live in the present, and also to talk about it with my coach. It really made me reflect upon what my mindset was at the time. And then looking back on those mindsets, I realize I've made a big change in how my mindset has shifted.

BERNIE BANKS: It's interesting that we didn't know those questions would be posed — and yet the themes that came up, thinking intentionally about the life you're leading, building strong community, fostering a greater sense of love for those around you, are the very same things you spoke about in 2007. They're still present in the Rice experience today. I think that is wonderful.

JOHN DOERR: It goes to the central question of making meaning out of life.

Part II: Mentorship and Values

JOHN DOERR: I want to use that as a segue to mentorship — and tell you all how important I think mentors are and how fortunate you can be to have a good one, or two, throughout the course of your career.

A lot of the story of Andy Grove's mentorship of me and others is in *Measure What Matters*. The best part of the book, I should warn you, is the dedication — to two extraordinary people. One is Andy Grove. The other you may know less about: Coach Bill Campbell. He was chairman of the board of Columbia's football program. He compiled their worst record, but never mind that. I recruited him out of Apple after a business decision John Sculley had made. He went on to take Intuit public. He was a transformational leader beyond a doubt.

When you pick up a copy of the book, Chapter 18 is dedicated to Bill Campbell. I won't try to summarize his life, except to say that he did something unusual: he brought love into the leadership work experience. He made everyone he was mentoring — not just the CEO but every member of the team — better. More than most, he prioritized family. He said, "People are the most important thing we do. We've got to try and make people better."

BERNIE BANKS: That's a great opportunity to talk about this notion of what it means to be a great leader. You've had the opportunity to work with some of the most impactful people on the planet. For the ones you personally regard as great, what made them great?

JOHN DOERR: Their values — and then their commitment to communication. To enable and empower a team, they had to be effective, authentic communicators.

Let me share a slide on values. My mentor Andy Grove wrote a book called *Only the Paranoid Survive*. I used to argue with him about it. I said, "Andy, paranoia is a disease state. Instead of paranoia, we can use passion — a more positive and durable motivator." He never agreed with me, but the argument was worthwhile.

I would say: mercenaries are opportunistic — always interested in pitching the deal — whereas missionaries are strategic, focused on creating a partnership around a big idea. Mercenaries are sprinting for the short run; missionaries know they're in a marathon for the long run. Jeff Bezos famously said he didn't want Amazon to obsess over competitors — he wanted them to obsess over the customer, creating the world's most customer-centric company.

In a mercenary culture, you'll find an aristocracy of founders. In a missionary culture, you have a meritocracy where the best idea wins — not just the founder's idea. Mercenary cultures are defined by their financial statements; missionary cultures are defined by their mission and values. In a mercenary culture, you are on your own and it is a lonely road and there is an attitude of entitlement. Contrasted with a mentoring and geocaching culture where you value the contribution. There's also a difference — as my partner Randy Komisar wrote in *The Monk and the Riddle* — between a deferred life plan and a whole life plan. One runs on the lust for money alone. If an entrepreneur tells me they are not interested in making money, I don't believe them. The better path is to pursue meaning and money together: to achieve both success and significance in the work you do.

Part III: Technology Tsunamis

BERNIE BANKS: You've had the privilege of engaging with a variety of organizations over the last five decades, helping shape technologies that have changed our lives. You sit at the intersection of a lot of different fields of endeavour. With respect to technology, where do you think we are right now, and what do you see in the near and not-so-distant future?

JOHN DOERR: We're experiencing an extreme tsunami that is very hard to forecast. But let me take you back 40 or 50 years.

The first tsunami was Moore's Law, which led to the microchip and the personal computer — right around 1980, the same time Compaq was founded here in Houston. Moore's Law held strong, doubling roughly every two years.

Then, about 13 years later, an undergrad from the University of Illinois, Marc Andreessen, started a company called Netscape and made the internet accessible to everyone — point-and-click. The Netscape browser was introduced to the world in December 1994.

What came 13 years after that? 2007.

AUDIENCE MEMBER: The iPhone!

The iPhone — and not incidentally, cloud computing. I don't think you can imagine the iPhone without the cloud, or the cloud without the iPhone. This time two tsunamis came together at once and created extraordinary value.

That first iPhone didn't have an App Store, by the way. Steve Jobs on one afternoon pulled the iPhone out of his pocket, and said, "John, this thing nearly killed our company." He said, "We put five radios and a touchscreen into one device — no fixed plastic buttons — and it had never been done before." I turned the phone over and saw "4GB" on the back. I said, "Is that 4 gigabytes?" He said yes — and I said there's never been that much storage in a mobile device before. I asked about third-party apps. He said, "John, I'm not interested in having my device

polluted by crummy software." Steve was great at saying no as a leader. But also paying attention to what was going on in the market. Of course, everyone eventually jailbroke that iPhone anyway, which is what led Apple to open the App Store and enable an entire app economy.

Then, 13 years after that, brings us to November 2022. What happened then?

AUDIENCE MEMBER: OpenAI launched ChatGPT.

JOHN DOERR: Exactly. OpenAI introduced ChatGPT. Artificial intelligence is unlocking capabilities we thought were unthinkable. It builds on all these previous tsunamis — and we're just at the beginning.

I was in a meeting recently with Bill Gates, and he confessed, with a degree of frustration and humility, that for the first time in his career he couldn't anticipate what was going to happen in computing three to five years out. So I ask: who here has a clear view of what technology will look like in three years? If you do, I want to talk to you afterward.

BERNIE BANKS: Given all this technological change, how do we overlay it against societal forces? Many folks say the social compact is being stressed in serious ways. Is this just a moment in time, or a fundamental shift?

JOHN DOERR: I think it's the latter — it's very fundamental. We don't need to know exactly where we're going to know that we're entering a period of tremendous change, ambiguity, and opportunity. The social contract matters more than ever. We need strong institutions to guide us and chart the course into this new, uncertain world.

America has been a great engine of innovation, but I'm very troubled by threats to the funding of higher education. The compact between great universities and our country has produced opportunity and prosperity for the world. Left to its own devices, technology widens the gap between the rich and the poor. The offsetting force is education, which creates upward mobility and opportunity — or at least it has until now. How we take on those challenges at Rice University, in partnership with federal and state governments, is a pressing question.

I used to say Rice and Stanford are great universities. Now I say they're *important* universities — because we need to be more than great. We need to solve the pressing problems confronting us. Rice is leading in the sciences, in healthcare and sustainability, in space. And Texas, which may surprise you, is the national leader in renewable energy deployment. We're going to be a leader in neurological research. People are moving from California to Texas, and it's not only about lower taxes — it's about pursuing great opportunities.

The role of education, when everyone will have their own personal AI tutor. The role of healthcare, our largest expense and greatest challenge. The role that will be played in space. The role that you choose to play in that future is crucial.

Part IV: Career Advice

BERNIE BANKS: One final question before we open it up: what career advice would you give the young people in the audience today, given all you've seen and all they'll have to navigate going forward?

JOHN DOERR: That's a hard question.

BERNIE BANKS: We love hard questions at Rice.

JOHN DOERR: A profound shift in employment, jobs, and careers is underway. Anybody who tells you otherwise, I think, is not leveling with you. The employment situation at Rice may be good right now — most graduates are finding jobs they want — but I don't think we can count on that continuing as before.

I've gathered advice from people I respect, though I'm not certain it's all correct. I'll share it anyway. This shift is real. You need to show up for it. You need to be indispensable. You need to harness AI. You need to be the first generation of Americans who are AI natives — who can't imagine a time when we didn't have AI helping us navigate the world.

It's important that you take a long view in the midst of the immediate uncertainty. When I told Andy Grove I was going to go into venture capital, he said, "Doerr, that's not a real job — that's like real estate. Go make something. Go manage a team, lead, and make something." I think he was right, because if you believe it takes teams to win, then your ability to communicate, inspire, inform, and challenge the people you work with will be the single greatest measure of your career — second only to love for your family.

Learn how to sell. Learn how to manage people. Learn how to network, and do it relentlessly. In my senior year at Rice, I pretty much ignored my academic studies because I wanted to interview everywhere I possibly could and figure out what the world was like. I did a form of networking that wasn't social networking — it was personal relationship networking. I contacted maybe 20 companies and stayed in touch with those people over time.

Look for the next high-growth opportunity. Try to find it. You may not find it, but if you can get into an advanced AI company, an innovative pharmaceutical design firm using these technologies, or a business of your own that you start with your friends. I remember forming a software consulting company in my senior year at Rice. I applied for a radio license for KTRU. I made sure the license went to the students, not the administration. I sold advertising for KTRU radio. I worked on the R-2 computer, a mainframe that we adopted.. I was an intern at Monsanto. And I almost flunked out of calculus. But my roommate was good, and he helped me out.

I think there is going to come a time when you are ready to strike out on your own, when you swing for the stands, to be an entrepreneur, or a part of an organization founded by entrepreneurs. There I think you want to create a missionary kind of culture.

Steve Jobs said all you need to do is follow your passion. I disagree. The challenge is greater than that. You need to make sure you're *great* at your passion, not just good. You should also make sure your passion can support you and your family — if it doesn't pay well, maybe it should be your hobby. Develop mentors. Network like crazy. Go to where the action is. And always — always — give back.

A lot of these ideas about thriving in a career come from a new book by Bill Gurley, a Texan and retired venture capitalist from Benchmark, who lays out in a practical and useful way how to thrive in a career you actually love. I also recommend *The Defining Decade* by Dr. Meg Jay — especially for undergraduates. It has deeply practical advice about building the relationships that will sustain you for a lifetime.

Part V: Audience Q&A

The following topics were raised by the audience and addressed by John Doerr and Bernie Banks:

Q: Consolidation vs. Fragmentation in Tech With the rise of AI, do you see more fragmentation — where the average person can build something on their own — or more consolidation?

JOHN DOERR: Short answer: the competition is fierce and the landscape is shifting in both directions simultaneously.

Q: The Role of the Humanities You emphasize the importance of valuing people and humanity in effective leadership. What is the role of the humanities — and the partnership between humanities and sciences — in this transformation? Thinking about complex history, languages, intercultural understanding, ethical grounding, and thinking beyond AI's capacity.

BERNIE BANKS: That is a wonderful and important question. I'll let John address the humanity piece, but I'll say this: if we lose sight of what it means to be human, that is the end of days. We have to understand what it means to be human — how we advance our love of music, culture, science, all of it. The technology we create should serve to enhance the human experience, not eradicate it.

Our ability to think in nonlinear ways is expanded by our exploration of the humanities. To build great technology, you have to start by understanding what it means to be human. The people who will do the best job leveraging technology going forward are those with a well-rounded education — not simply steep in STEM, but holistic in perspective.

JOHN DOERR: I agree completely. I think Rice does this exceptionally well — in part because of our culture, in part because of our size. We integrate the humanities and the arts with engineering and science. Look at this beautiful building we're in — it's evidence of that integration. It's absolutely critical. What would Rice be without the Shepherd School of Music? It's remarkable what those artists bring to bear.

Personally, I think it's too early to reduce questions of what it means to be human to a computational problem. The engineering side of me wishes we could. The student of science says we may not be able to — we still don't fully understand how the human brain works.

Q: Technology, Social Media, and Emotional Intelligence Given the importance of leadership and emotional intelligence, how do you view the juxtaposition of those qualities against how technology — and social media in particular — is changing how people interact?

JOHN DOERR: I think the jury is still out, and reasonable people can be optimistic or pessimistic. What I'm confident about is that leadership and emotional intelligence are *more* important, not less, in a world saturated with digital interaction. Authentic human connection doesn't get automated away.

Q: Authenticity in Leadership How do you implement authenticity in leadership?

JOHN DOERR: I think authentic leadership means being a servant leader — knowing that the success of your group is more important than your individual success. You have to *live* that. You see it in great team sports. Look at the culture Steve Kerr has built with the Golden State Warriors. Those are real lessons in servant leadership. Be yourself, even as you're relying on mentors and fellow travelers as you figure out who you are.

Q: Neuroscience and Venture Given developments at the Rice Neuroengineering Initiative and in Houston's medical community, how could neuroscience be incorporated into a venture focused on self-improvement and brain enhancement?

JOHN DOERR: I think it's still early — we don't yet fully understand how the human brain works. That said, if we get a more fundamental understanding of how the brain operates, it would make artificial intelligence significantly more successful. Dennis Hassabis, the founder of DeepMind, doesn't believe we'll get to AGI purely through scaling language models — he thinks we need some more fundamental algorithmic breakthroughs. The brain remains the most important open scientific and engineering problem of our time.

Q: Riding the Wave — Distinguishing Signal from Noise What have you learned about identifying truly transformative technologies in an environment with constant new releases and overwhelming noise?

JOHN DOERR: It's a pattern recognition challenge more than anything. Go back to that wave graphic: each tsunami built on the one before it. The microchip gave us the PC. The PC enabled the browser. The browser and cloud together enabled the smartphone. Now AI builds on all of it.

When evaluating a technology, I ask: does it build on or accelerate the wave underneath it? Is it unlocking new classes of applications that weren't possible before? And most importantly — are the people behind it missionaries or mercenaries? The signal is usually the team and the depth of the problem they're solving. The noise tends to be whoever has the best PR that week.

Q: AI and Climate — Made Better or Worse? In a world being disrupted by AI, is the climate crisis being addressed, made worse, or made better?

JOHN DOERR: Both, and we have to be honest about that. Energy demand from AI is going through the roof — it's an enormous challenge. But it's also an enormous opportunity. The leading hyperscaler companies are standing by their commitments to decarbonize their energy grids. Right now they're largely doing that with natural gas, and hydrogen and deep geothermal are promising alternatives. We just got an update on a major commitment Google has made in that direction.

What we're seeing with energy vulnerability — the current geopolitical situation is proof of why fossil fuel dependence is a strategic risk. We must rely on fossil fuels for now, but we also must be committed to a transition away from them. Don't lose sight of that as an imperative.

I co-authored *Speed and Scale* precisely because I believe the climate crisis is addressable — but only if we act with urgency and hold large institutions accountable for the commitments they've made.

Q: Productivity, AI, and the Future of Work: Could We Reach a 4-Day (or 3-Day) Work Week?

JOHN DOERR: I'll put this alongside the bigger question: what about *no* jobs, or a radically different definition of jobs? This is, genuinely, the next big thing. The honest answer is that productivity gains from technology have historically created more work, not less — but AI may be categorically different. I think the work week question is tied to how we redistribute the gains from this productivity revolution, and that is fundamentally a political and cultural question, not just a technological one.

Q: Companies Not Solving Their Negative Externalities A lot of companies in power aren't doing much to address the negative externalities of their business models. How do you think about that — especially given that not many are signing up for the Giving Pledge?

JOHN DOERR: I believe in a society of free will and free action. Leaders who don't have the right values won't retain the right workforce — and right now there is a fierce war for talent. Ultimately, I believe that force realigns incentives.

On charitable giving: the U.S. is the most generous nation for charitable giving, by far, among all countries. And it's remarkable that someone who was — or still is — among the wealthiest people in the world has committed to giving away their entire fortune within 20 years, directed at childhood mortality and disease in the developing world. That matters enormously. Could we be more generous? Yes. Must we be? Yes.

Q: The Evolution of Venture Capital as Companies Stay Private Longer Companies like SpaceX, OpenAI, and Anthropic are choosing to stay private at unprecedented valuations. How do you see venture investing evolving to accommodate that?

JOHN DOERR: Venture capital is going through a lot of change, like every industry. It is a uniquely American advantage. Companies that develop liquid markets for their shares — to reward employees and fuel further growth — will continue to do so.

I'll tell you honestly: the sums of money being invested, and the valuations, are terrifying. I'm out there investing alongside them, and I find it sobering.

Closing

BERNIE BANKS: John, thank you so much for your insight today. This has been a truly special conversation.

JOHN DOERR: Thank you, Rice! Go Owls!

[End of Fireside Chat]